

What is a Lighthouse?

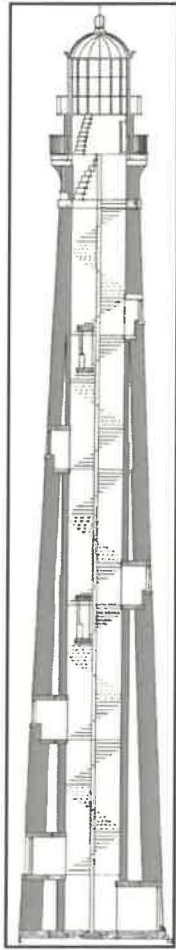
A lighthouse is a tower with a very bright light at the top called a **beacon**. The beacon is used by sailors to help guide their ships at night.

Lighthouses come in all shapes and sizes. They are usually located on the coast, on islands, or in the middle of busy harbors. They guide ships in and out of inlets as well as warn sailors about dangerous **shoals** (rocky or shallow places). There are so many dangerous shoals along the Outer Banks of North Carolina that this area is called the **Graveyard of the Atlantic**.

Some lighthouses are tall and some are short. Some are square and some are **conical** (cone shaped). Some are attached to **Keepers' Quarters** and some stand alone. Most have distinct **daymarks** (colors and patterns used to identify the lighthouse), but some don't.

Each lighthouse is unique but they all serve the same purpose and, therefore, have many things in common.

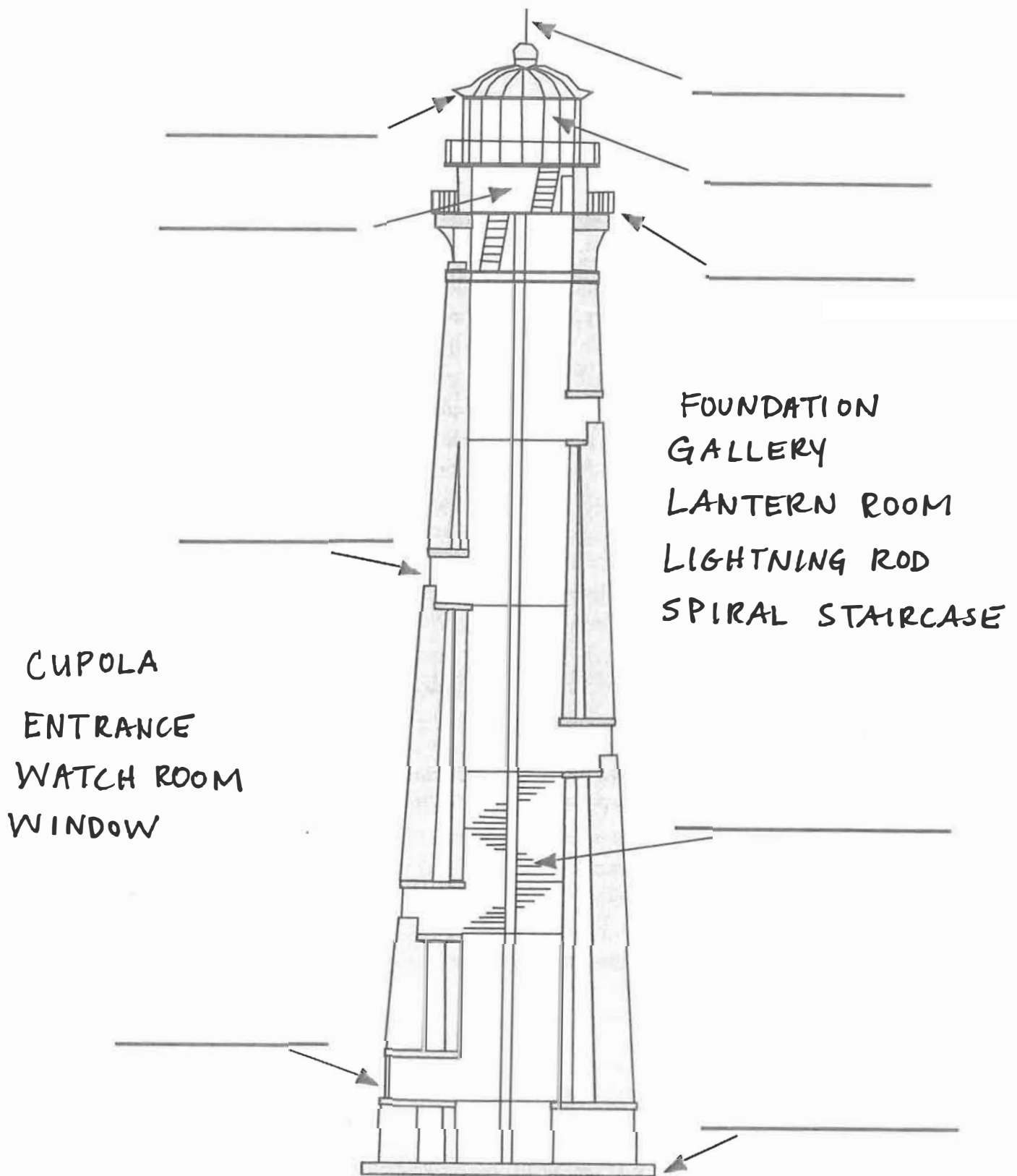
All lighthouses have a **beacon** (light) at the top. The beacon is housed in a room called the **lantern room** which has large windows all around and is topped with a domed roof called a **cupola**. A **spiral staircase** (or sometimes a ladder) provides a way to climb to the top of the tower. Most lighthouses also have a room for storage called a **service room** and **watch room** where the keeper kept watch on the light making sure it did not go out. Nearly all lighthouses include a small walkway around the outside of the tower called the **gallery**, a **lightning rod**, **windows**, and of course an **entrance**. But, one of the most important part of a lighthouse is its **foundation**. Without a sturdy foundation, the lighthouse would surely fall over.



*** Use the vocabulary words (the ones in bold print) to label the lighthouse on the following page.***

*** The "Vocabulary List" can help with definitions.

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Vocabulary

Beacon	a device designed to attract attention to a specific place
Conical	cone shape without a point at the top
Cupola	domed shape roof on the lantern room
Daymark	pattern which a lighthouse is painted so it looks different from other lighthouses during the day
Entrance	door leading into the lighthouse
Fixed Light	steady light that does not flash
Flash Pattern	pattern of light and darkness for the lighthouse so it looks different from other lighthouses during the night
Fresnel Lens	(fray-NAL) a type of lens developed by Frenchman Augustin-Jean Fresnel that uses hundreds of pieces of glass to concentrate light into a stronger beam
Foundation	a large flat structure that keeps the lighthouse from falling over
Gallery	a platform that circles the tower just below the lantern room
Graveyard of the Atlantic	an area along North Carolina coast that is very dangerous and is known for numerous shipwrecks
Keepers' Quarters	house or place where the lighthouse keepers lived
Lantern Room	a room at the top of lighthouse with glass walls that contains the lamp and lens
Light Characteristic	light color and flash patterns used to identify lighthouses at night
Lighthouse Board	part of the U. S. government that took care of lighthouses and paid the keepers from 1852- 1910
Lighthouse Keeper	person responsible for tending and caring for a lighthouse
Lightning Rod	metal poles attached to top of a building to help stop the damage created by lightning strikes, the rods are connected to a copper wire connected to the ground so that the lightning will run down into the ground instead in the building

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